

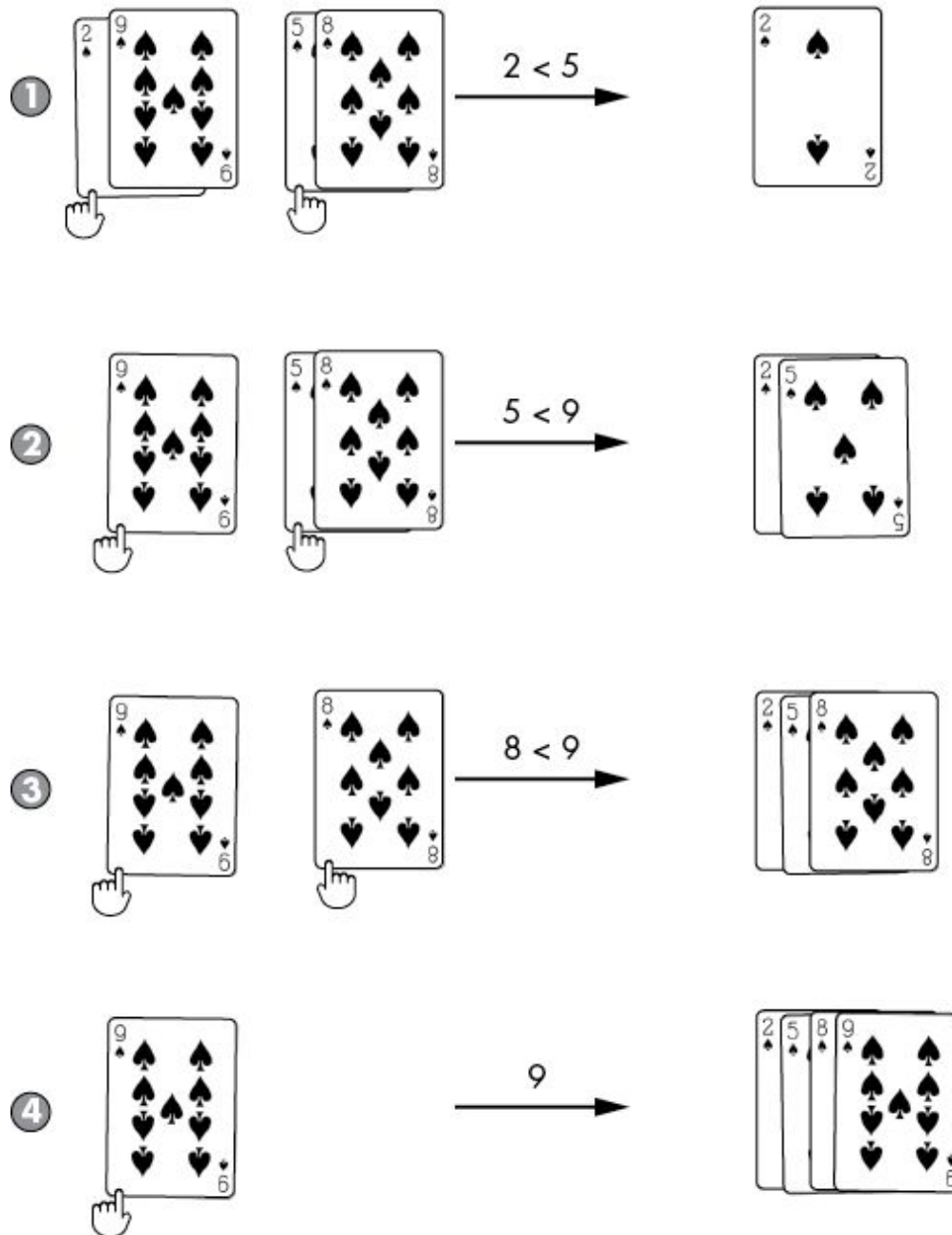


Figure 5-4: The merge step compares the two values at the start of the smaller sorted lists and moves them to the larger sorted list. Merging four cards requires only four steps.

Let's ask our three recursive algorithm questions about the merge sort algorithm:

What is the base case? Being given a list to sort that has zero or one item in it, which is already in sorted order.